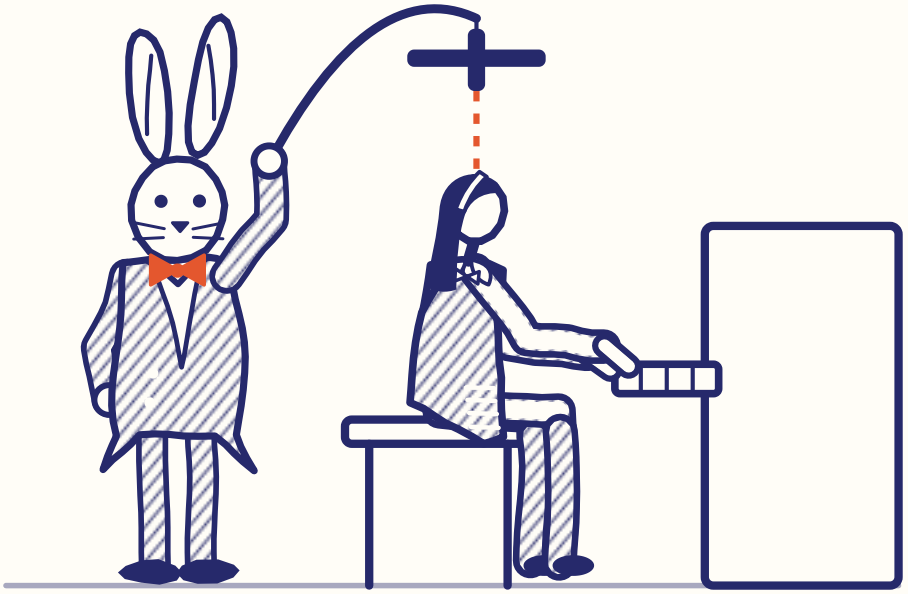
CHAPTER 1

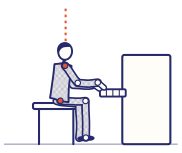
Sit Tall, Round Hands



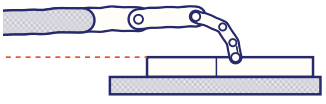
Clara is about to play her very first note. **Two secrets first:** how to sit, and how to hold your hands.

GUESS Which finger is number 1? Guess now. The answer is on page 5.

BY THE END OF THIS CHAPTER I CAN



sit tall at the piano



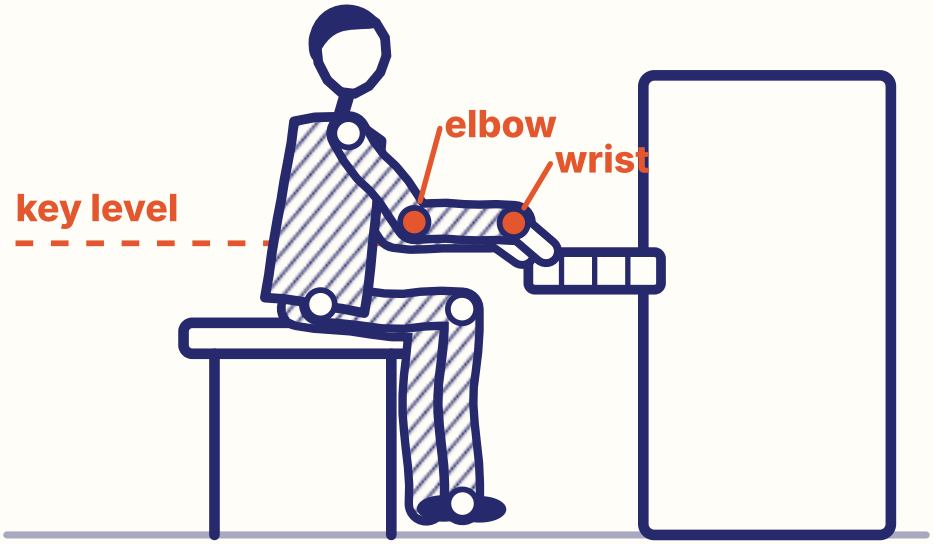
make a round hand



say every finger number

STEP 1

Sit at the piano

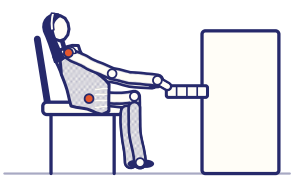


Front half of the stool. **Feet flat.** Elbows **just in front** of you.

Try it at the piano

1. Sit on the front half of the stool, feet flat on the floor. ○
2. Move the stool until your arm is level with the keys. ○
3. Slide in or out until your elbows are just in front of you. ○

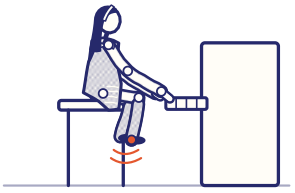
NOT LIKE THIS



× leaning back



× too close

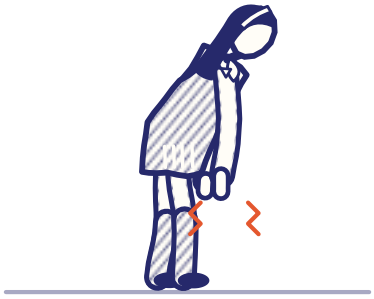


× feet swinging

STEP 2

Floppy and free

Before you play, shake out the stiffness. Big parts first.



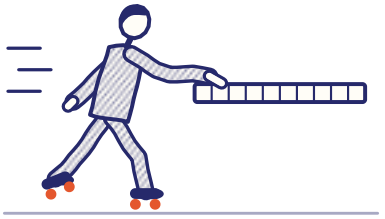
Rag doll

Flop forward. Let your arms hang heavy, then shake them loose.



Elbow wings

Float your elbows out like wings, then let them drop.



Arm glide

Skate your whole arm along the keys. The hand just rides.

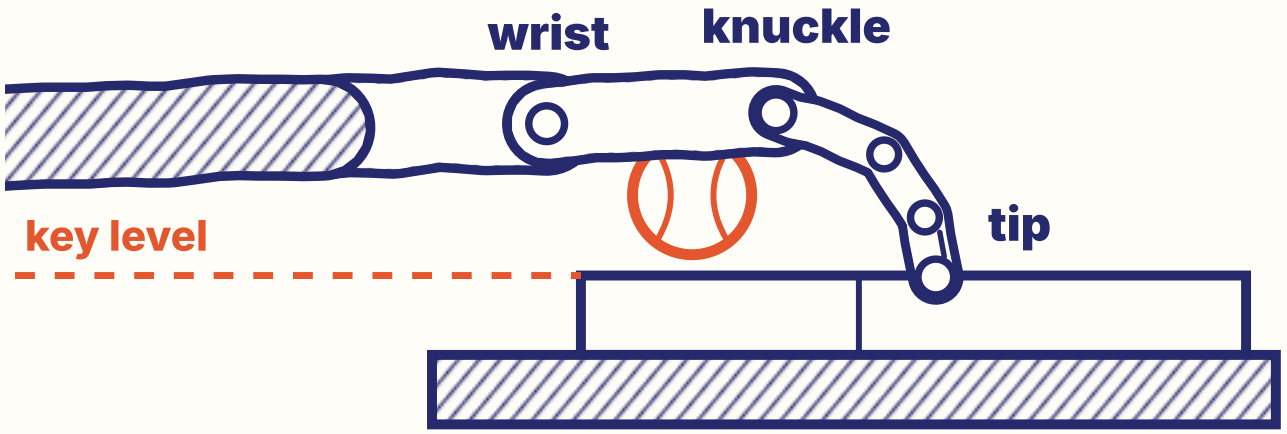


Your fingers do not play alone. **The whole arm** carries them, like a crane carrying a bucket.

CHALLENGE Do all three in order with your eyes closed. Can you do it twice?

STEP 3

A round hand



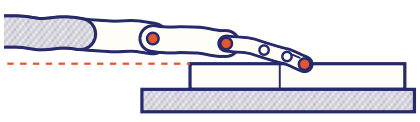


Hold a little ball in your hand. Now put the ball on the keys. **Don't squash it!**

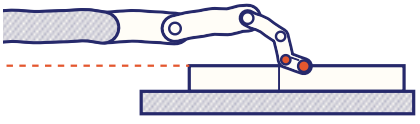
Try it at the piano

1. Knuckles up, like a bridge.
2. Play on the very tip of each finger.
3. Wrist soft: let it sway, as if a roller sat under it.

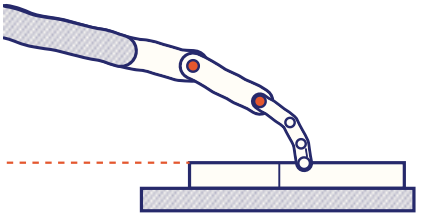
NOT LIKE THIS



× flat fingers



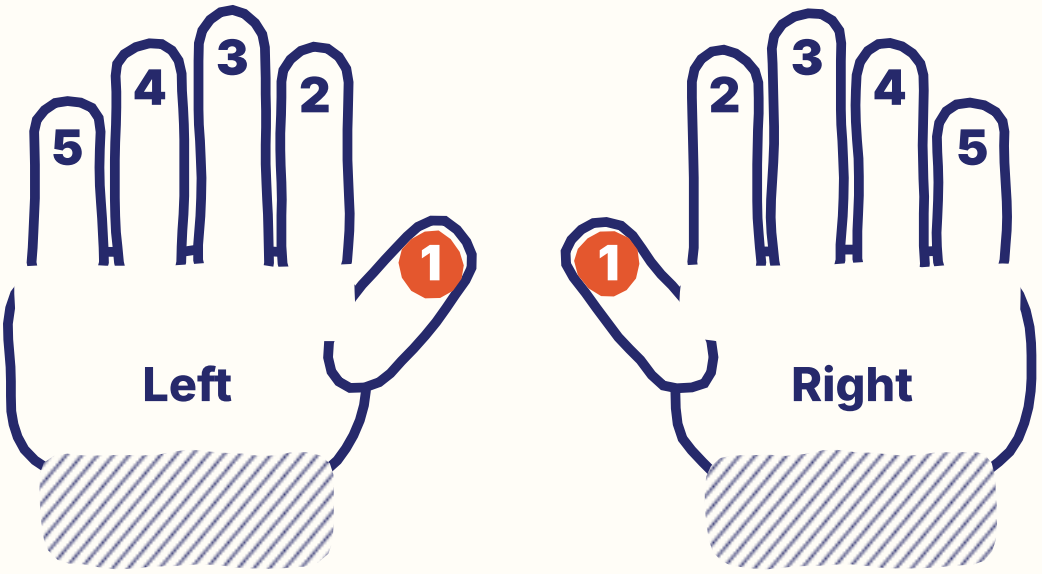
× tip caving in



× wrist too high

STEP 4

Finger numbers



Thumbs are **1**. Little fingers are **5**. The same on both hands.

(Page 1's answer: the thumb!)

1 Captain Thumb · **2** Pointer · **3** Tall Middle · **4** Shy Ring · **5** Baby Pinky



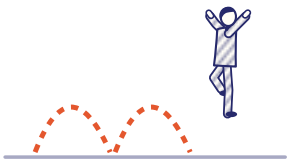
The mirror game

Someone calls **"Right hand, 3!"** and you wiggle that finger. Ten calls, as fast as you can. Then swap.

PLAY

Finger walks

Sit well, make a round hand and play. One circle is one steady beat.



Hop on 3

3 3 3 | 3 3 3



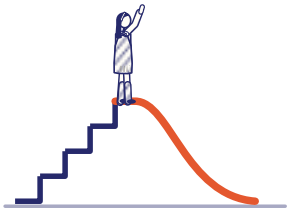
Neighbours

2 3 2 3 | 3 2 3 2



Little hill

1 2 3 2 1



Stairs and slide

1 2 3 4 5 | 5 4 3 2 1



Right hand first, then left. Your hand draws **a little rainbow** from key to key.

CHECK-UP

My five checks

Show your teacher (or a grown-up) each one at the piano. Colour a circle.



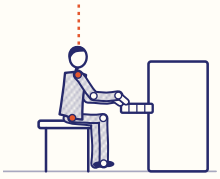
Front half of the stool

not yet · nearly · ★



Feet flat on the floor

not yet · nearly · ★



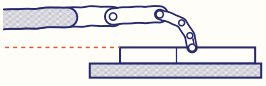
Sitting tall, like a puppet on a string

not yet · nearly · ★



Arm level with the keys

not yet · nearly · ★



Round hand, playing on the tips

not yet · nearly · ★



All five stars? Then the first floor's door is open. **Well done, Clara!**